

touching the metal. All it takes is two contacts to touch some metal, and then you power up your computer, hear a terrible pop sound, smell something burning and realise that it's time to buy a new board—and maybe even a new CPU and RAM as well, if you're unlucky enough. So, remember, you've been warned!

We found that none of the screw holes made for the circuit board lined up with those of the motherboard. Oh well, can't win everything. We used the hand-drill to drill a few holes into the metal board holder, and pinched a few of those elevated screws from our cabinet and then screwed the motherboard in. We were satisfied that it was well held in place—which, incidentally, isn't too much of a worry, because in a CRT, the board sits parallel to the table, unlike in most cabinets, where the motherboard is fixed vertically.

Next, we took the motherboard out again, used generous amounts of cellophane tape (you should use insulation tape) to cover any areas that the board seems to be touching the metal and checked by frequently seating and unseating the motherboard. Once we were satisfied that there was no way we'd fry the motherboard by turning it on, we prepared to cut away some parts of the metal holder to allow access to the inputs that are behind the motherboard.

Once the motherboard was seated, we attached the metal board holder back to the CRT's front casing. Now all we had left was the back casing to take care of.

Back Breaking

The back half of the casing is where we planned to house the power supply, the hard disk and the DVD-Writer. Our biggest worry thus far had been where we'd seat the DVD-Writer, and to be honest, we were stumped. One very good suggestion we got along the way was to buy a laptop DVD-Writer, remove the casing, and then fix it to the front panel of the CRT casing. Though this would work well, and look a lot better than any of the other options we had, we decided against it because we had started this mod on the premise that this would be the cheapest case mod ever.

If you're OK with spending a few extra bucks, and want to try this at home, you should seriously consider buying a laptop optical drive, and integrating it into the front casing of the CRT. These drives are really thin, and will fit well into the space between the LCD and the CRT bezel. Besides, the finished product will look a lot better than what we ended up with.

Since we insisted on using our favourite Plextor DVD-Writer, we had no choice but to attach it to the top of the CRT case. This means our mod looks like a CRT monitor with an optical drive lying on top of it, but at least we didn't spend any extra money!

In order to fix the optical drive to the case, we would have to drill holes, but how? Luckily we had a cabinet with a vertical holder for optical drives. We detached this and used it to mark our holes. At home, if you don't have access to this, you will have to very carefully pencil the outline of the drive onto the case, and then use precise measurements to mark the holes. You should also check each hole as soon as

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you make it, so that you can correct it immediately, or compensate accordingly.

We just used the soldering iron to make the holes—it's just the easiest way. You can just knock off all the little extra bits of melted plastic using your screwdriver, and find that you have a very neat hole. The one thing you need to remember is that the optical drive needs power and an IDE cable coming to it. Because we decided to place the drive on top, we had to make an opening to get power and IDE cables out to the drive. We did this using the soldering iron and the file.

Once that was done, we then looked for space to put the power supply. The little extra bulge that the CRT case has on the back is perfect. It's far enough away from the processor and RAM to allow decent cooling and airflow. We suggest you attach it as high up as you can to get as much distance between the motherboard and power supply as possible. This is exactly what we did.

With the power supply, it's not as easy as drilling a few holes, because you also have the fan and connectors to account for. This means that you're basically going to have to make a rather large opening behind the CRT case, and you cannot use a saw. First things first: we drilled the holes for the screws. Mark them carefully as instructed before, and then check them thoroughly. Once done, you know that those screw holes have to be there and well-supported, because they will bear the load of the power supply.

What we did was roughly mark out an opening in pencil (conservative estimate again), making sure to stay as far away from the screw holes as possible. We then used the soldering iron to melt away the plastic along the line we had marked. Once we had our opening, we kept using the power supply as a reference (attaching and detaching it), and marking new lines and curves that were needed to free access to the connectors and the fan. Then we just used the metal file to shape the plastic, filing it down carefully till we were satisfied. A very common mistake people will make at home is just assuming that the power supply has its screw holes symmetrically placed. This isn't true: if you look at the power supply behind your cabinet, you will see that the screws are asymmetric. So be very careful and precise when marking these screw holes.

Next, it was the hard drive's turn. This was the simplest bit of the mod, because we had already decided to attach it to the side of the CRT case. Most CRTs have a lot of ventilation holes on their sides, and we used these to screw the hard disk into place. Because we wanted to give it some distance from the motherboard, we did make two holes (again, with the soldering iron) and attached it to the inside of the case.

Finally, we had to shape the back of the CRT case to accommodate the back of the motherboard. This we did using the file, and though it was a laborious job, it was much neater in the end. We also had to make an opening for the LCD's power and display cables, which need to come out of the case and connect from the outside. These cables are what make the mod look ugly, but it cannot be helped. Let us know if you have suggestions. If you have a graphics card, however, you can reduce one cable by con-